

Rasburicase (Fasturtec®)

Rasburicase (Fasturtec®) is a drug given before and during chemotherapy to treat some types of cancer. It can help to prevent tumour lysis syndrome.

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What is tumour lysis syndrome?

Chemotherapy uses anti-cancer (cytotoxic) drugs to destroy cancer cells. When cancer cells break down very quickly, it can cause a sudden release of large amounts of chemicals into the blood. This is called tumour lysis syndrome (TLS).

Your kidneys can usually keep these chemicals balanced. But they might not be able to cope with very large amounts. The chemical imbalance can affect how well your kidneys work and cause problems with your heart rhythm.

You will have regular blood tests to check the levels of these chemicals.

If you are at risk of TLS, your doctor can give you treatment to help prevent it. You may have:

- extra fluids through a drip
- medicines such as rasburicase or allopurinol.

Drinking at least 2 litres (3½ pints) of fluid a day will also help.

How rasburicase is given

Rasburicase is given before or with your first chemotherapy treatment. You have it as a drip (infusion) into a vein.

Your nurse will give you rasburicase through 1 of the following:

- a [cannula](#) – a short, thin tube the nurse puts into a vein in your arm or hand

- a [central line](#) – a fine tube that goes under the skin of your chest and into a vein close by
- a [PICC line](#) – a fine tube that is put into a vein in your arm and goes up into a vein in your chest.

The infusion is given over 30 minutes. You may have just 1 dose or a daily dose for up to 7 days. You will have blood tests to see how much uric acid is in your blood. This helps your doctor decide how many doses of rasburicase to give you.

You will also have an infusion of fluids to help flush through your kidneys. This is called intravenous hydration. This means you pass more urine (pee) than usual.

About side effects

Each person's reaction to any medicine is different. Most people have very few side effects, while others may experience more. The side effects described here will not affect everyone who is having rasburicase.

You may also have side effects from the cancer drugs you are given. If you notice any side effects that are not listed here, tell your nurse or doctor.

Serious and life-threatening side effects

Some cancer treatments can cause serious side effects. Sometimes, these may be life-threatening. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can explain the risk of these side effects to you.

Contact the hospital

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will give you 24-hour contact numbers for the hospital. If you feel unwell or need advice, you can call at any time of the day or night. Save these numbers in your phone or keep them somewhere safe.

More information about this treatment

This information is correct at time of publishing.

We cannot list every side effect for this treatment. There are some rare side effects that are not listed

You can talk to your cancer team if you want more detailed information about this treatment. Or visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium](#) (eMC) website, which has patient information leaflets (PILs) for individual drugs.

Side effects while treatment is being given

Some people may have side effects while they are having a cancer drug or shortly after they have it:

Allergic reaction

Some people have an allergic reaction while having this treatment. Signs of a reaction can include:

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- feeling hot or flushed
- shivering
- itching
- a skin rash
- feeling dizzy or sick
- a headache
- feeling breathless or wheezy
- swelling of your face or mouth
- pain in your back, tummy or chest.

Your nurse will check you for signs of a reaction during your treatment. If you feel unwell or have any of these signs, tell them straight away. If you do have a reaction, they can treat it quickly.

Sometimes a reaction happens a few hours after treatment. If you develop any of these signs or feel unwell after you get home, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number.

Always call 999 if swelling happens suddenly or you are struggling to breathe.

Very common side effects

These side effects happen to 10 or more people in every 100 people (10% or more) who have this treatment.

High temperature

Your nurse will monitor your temperature during treatment. Signs of a high temperature can include feeling hot and sweaty or cold and shivery. It is important to let the nurse or doctor know if your temperature goes over 37.5°C (99.5°F).

Feeling sick

The nurses will give you anti-sickness drugs regularly. This will help prevent or control sickness during your treatment in hospital. [If you feel sick](#) or are sick (vomit), tell your nurse or doctor straight away. They can change the anti-sickness treatment. Or they might change the way you have it to something that works better for you.

Diarrhoea

This treatment may cause [diarrhoea](#). Diarrhoea means passing more stools (poo) than is normal for you, or having watery or loose stools. You may also have stomach cramps. If you have a stoma, it may be more active than usual.

If you are passing loose stools 3 or more times a day and this is not normal for you, contact the hospital as soon as possible on the 24-hour number. Follow the advice they give you about:

- taking anti-diarrhoea medicines

- drinking enough fluids to keep you hydrated and to replace lost salts and minerals
- any changes to your diet that might help.

They might also ask you for a specimen of your stool to check for infection.

Headaches

This treatment may cause headaches. If you have headaches, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can give you advice about painkillers that may help. Tell them if the headache does not get better, or gets worse.

Other side effects

These side effects happen to less than 10 in 100 people (less than 10%) who have this treatment. Some of them are much rarer than this but they are still important to know about. Rare means a side effect that happens to less than 1 in 1,000 people (less than 0.1%).

Blood changes

Rarely, rasburicase can increase the breakdown of red blood cells. You will have regular blood tests during your treatment to check for this side effect.

Other information

Other medicines

Some medicines can affect how this treatment works or be harmful while you are having it. Always tell your cancer doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any drugs you are taking or planning to take, such as:

- medicines you have been prescribed
- medicines you buy in a shop, pharmacy or online
- vitamins or supplements
- [herbal drugs and complementary or homeopathic therapies](#)
- recreational drugs – for example, cannabis.

Pregnancy

Ask your doctor or pharmacist for advice before taking this medicine if you:

- are pregnant
- think you may be pregnant
- are planning to have a baby.

Breastfeeding

You are advised not to [breastfeed](#) while having this treatment, or for some time after treatment ends. This is because the drugs could be passed to the baby through breast milk.

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information.

Medical and dental treatment

If you need medical treatment for any reason other than cancer, always tell the healthcare professional that you are having cancer treatment. Give them the contact details for your cancer doctor or cancer team so they can ask for advice.

If you have appointments with a dentist, always tell them you are having cancer treatment. Talk to your cancer team before you have any dental treatment.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) to download a Patient Information Leaflet (PIL) for more detailed information. The leaflet lists all known side effects.

[Cancer Information Development team](#)

Author

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

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Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help